



Are you with us or against us? The role of threat and anger in sport sponsorship

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ABSTRACT

Identification with a sports team can represent an important component of a person's self-concept. Through sponsorship, brands attempt to leverage their affiliation with sports teams to transfer positive associations from the property to the brand. However, because of the competitive nature of sports - brands may enter into a sponsorship with a rival team. The current research considers the cognitive and emotional mechanisms through which fans respond to such sponsorships. Results indicate that highly identified fans experience threat in response to the sponsorship of a rival, this threat leads to anger which negatively influences attitudes towards the sponsorship and reduces purchase intentions. Practical and theoretical implications of these findings are discussed.

1. Introduction

Rivalries are an integral part of the experience of being a sports fan, and they often fuel attitudes, emotions, and behaviors that can impact sponsoring brands. For example, when Seattle-based Alaska Airlines signed to be the jersey sponsor of the Portland Timbers, a Major League Soccer (MLS) team, Alaska Airlines received hate mail from Seattle residents whose MLS team, the Sounders, had an intense rivalry with the Timbers. Even though Xbox was already the jersey sponsor of the Sounders - a deal that precluded Alaska Airlines from becoming the jersey sponsor - fans were angered by the fact that a Seattle-based company would sponsor the rival Portland team (Botta, 2012). Negative attitudes experienced and expressed by sports fans can clearly influence their response to rivals' sponsors; however, to our knowledge, existing research has not examined the specific causes and consequences of these negative attitudes in the context of sponsorship.

Our research addresses this gap by considering the impact of identification, threat, and anger on sponsorship attitudes and purchase intentions. In doing so, we identify the psychological processes that occur when fans encounter a rival team-brand partnership and demonstrate how those processes are likely (and unlikely) to lead to attitudinal and behavioral change. Such an investigation is valuable because it addresses the question of how sponsors can present their sponsorship of a property in ways that are less likely to alienate sports fans. For researchers, this work advances our theoretical understanding of the

affective and cognitive mechanisms underlying downstream effects of sponsoring rivals. Understanding this process in greater detail would allow researchers to more effectively capture the range of consumer responses so that future research is more reflective of actual sponsor-brand perceptions.

2. Theoretical background

2.1. Social identification and sponsorship

A social group consists of two or more individuals who have a collective perception of social unity based on a common social category (Turner, 1982). Group memberships are an important part of social life. Increasing social identification arises from the felt attachment between an individual and the groups with which they are affiliated (Brewer, 2008; Funk, 2008). When a person identifies strongly with a group, the values, goals, and norms of the group can become internalized, forming a prominent component of the individual's self-concept (Caddick, 1982). Because important group memberships are used to define a person's self-concept, evaluations of closely affiliated groups may be biased to enhance or protect that self-concept (Heine & Lehman, 1997). For example, as sports fans become increasingly identified with a team, events that affect the team are more strongly felt such that the team's success is viewed as a personal success and a team's failure is viewed as personal failure (Brewer, 1991; Cialdini et al., 1976; Hirt, Zillmann,

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Erickson, & Kennedy, 1992; Madrigal & Dalakas, 2008). Likewise, fans have been shown to bask in reflected glory (BIRG) by wearing team memorabilia following a victory and to cut off from reflective failure (CORF) following a loss by distancing themselves from the team (Cialdini et al., 1976). Highly identified fans CORF less and BIRG more than less identified fans (Wann & Branscombe, 1990). Related findings on intergroup behavior suggest that individuals exhibit discriminatory tendencies that favor members of the in-group over members of the out-group (Amiot, Sansfaçon, & Louis, 2014; Tajfel & Turner, 1979). For example, in-group members evaluate those who support their sports team more favorably than they evaluate supporters of a rival team (Wann & Dolan, 1994).

Not surprisingly, these discriminatory tendencies have been found to influence evaluations of closely aligned partners such as sponsors (Gwinner & Eaton, 1999; Madrigal, 2000). Previous research has identified both positive and negative transfer effects depending on the team affiliated with a sponsor. For example, fans transfer their strong liking for their favorite team to those associated with the team, including players, other fans, and sponsors (Gwinner, 1997). For out-groups, such as rival teams, fans transfer their negative feelings for the rival team to those who are associated with it, including team sponsors (Angell, Gorton, Bottomley, & White, 2016; Bee & Dalakas, 2015; Dalakas & Levin, 2005; Grohs, Reisinger, & Woisetschlager, 2015; Olson, 2018). Although much research has been conducted on positive and negative transfer effects in the context of sponsorship, very little research has considered the cognitive and emotional mechanisms through which these negative effects occur. Thus, we consider the effects of identification, threat, and anger on attitudes and intentions towards a brand sponsor.

2.2. Cognitive and emotional responses to sponsorship

2.2.1. Intergroup threat

Threat arises when an environmental stimulus puts an individual's well-being at risk, resulting in physiological, affective, cognitive, and behavioral changes that facilitate an adaptive response (Wager et al., 2009). Sometimes threats occur from relatively simple contexts – for example, a loud noise cracks across the room, indicating impending physical harm – but most often threats arise due to complex schemas that have developed via learning processes. These threats are frequently social in nature and occur when cues indicate challenges or negative evaluations from other people about one's competence, value, or status. These social threats also trigger acute physiological, cognitive, and emotional responses (Wager et al., 2009).

Group membership represents a major part of how individuals define and understand their self-concept. As a result, threats to group identity or viability from other groups or adversarial organizations are attention-grabbing, and this vigilance is often accompanied by strong emotions and the desire to reduce or eliminate the impact of these threats (Cottrell & Neuberg, 2005). Such threats arise when an out-group's characteristics or actions present a challenge to goal attainment, such as when groups compete for scarce resources, when intergroup values conflict, when group distinctiveness is undermined, or when the value or competence of the group is questioned (Branscombe, Ellemers, Spears, & Doosje, 1999; Riek, Mania, & Gaertner, 2006). In response, people are often motivated to act in order to protect the in-group in the face of threat, particularly when the in-group represents a central part of one's self-concept. Those individuals who are highly invested in and dependent on their group should have a greater sensitivity to perceived group threats, and they should be more likely to respond when threats are present (Branscombe et al., 1999; Cottrell & Neuberg, 2005). For example, when an in-group's competence or distinctiveness from similar groups are under threat, people who identify strongly with the in-group are especially likely to derogate competing out-groups, perceive greater in-group homogeneity, and self-stereotype (Branscombe et al., 1999).

Sports rivalries, with their high levels of perceived competition, conflicting goals, and strong levels of group identification, are a particularly explicit demonstration of how fans perceive threat and respond to it. Many sports feature clashes between teams or players that resonate strongly with fans and that are immortalized in lore. Sometimes these rivalries occur because teams are geographically close together (a threat to distinctiveness), because they compete for money or skilled players (a threat to scarce resources), or because they have a history of particularly fierce competition on the playing field (a threat to competence). As in-group identification increases, so do responses to threat; one famous NCAA college football rivalry features coaches who refuse to mention the name of their opponent aloud and rabid fans who eagerly follow their lead (The Associated Press, 2013). The sense of threat that results from rivalries is often used thematically by teams and brands in promotional campaigns. For example, an Under Armour promotion exhorted fans to “protect this house” (as described in Salter, 2005). In this way, the brand is capitalizing on the natural desire to attack and defend the team's home turf against opponents.

Sponsorship of a rival group also represents a threat to the in-group's identity and viability. A brand's sponsorship of a rival suggests a possible threat to the in-group and the performance of a fan's preferred team. The competitive nature of sports usually implies a zero-sum outcome – if a team is not a winner, it is a loser, and there can only be one champion. There is competition for resources and attention. By entering into an official sponsorship with a rival team, the brand signals that it has picked a side and by extension, places itself in opposition with an individual's preferred team. Thus, sponsorship of a rival implies that the brand endorses the out-group and is providing support and economic resources that could have otherwise gone to the favored team. Such an advantage may confer benefits to the rival team that would be damaging to the successful performance of the favored team. Further, consistent with prior work described above, individuals who are highly identified with a team should be most likely to perceive the sponsorship of a rival as a threat. More identified fans view their team as a part of their own identity and sponsoring a rival threatens that identity. This proposition is consistent with previous sponsorship research that indicates that highly identified fans react more strongly against rival sponsorships (Davies, Veloutsou, & Costa, 2006; Grohs et al., 2015), even when considering strong arguments about the sponsor (Bee & Dalakas, 2015). Thus, we hypothesize the following:

H1. Team sponsorship moderates the effect of identification on threat, such that highly identified fans will experience increased threat in response to a rival team sponsorship relative to fans who are less identified and relative to the sponsorship of a favored team.

2.2.2. Anger and fear as emotional consequences of threat

Much of the previous sponsorship research has considered the effect of valence-based affective responses (i.e., general positive or negative affect) or attitudes on sponsorship outcomes. In order to better predict fans' attitudinal and behavioral responses to sponsorships, it is important to consider not only the valence of the response but also specific emotions that may be elicited; as a result, we adopt an appraisal theory perspective. Appraisal theory posits that emotions are characterized by patterns of cognitive evaluations (called appraisals; Scherer, 1999; Smith & Ellsworth, 1985; Smith & Lazarus, 1993). In other words, emotions arise as a consequence of the particular ways in which people think about and assess a situation. For example, different appraisals lead to the emotions of admiration versus pride. Admiration is derived from appraisals of positive actions undertaken by another person whereas pride is premised upon positive actions undertaken by the self. Thus, the emotion felt (admiration versus pride) differs due to a change in assessed agency (other versus self). Likewise, many other appraisal dimensions have been proposed in the literature, including judgments about the intrinsic properties of an object or event (e.g., its novelty or agreeableness), the extent to which the event impacts one's ability to

achieve goals or fulfill needs, whether the person has the capacity to change or cope with consequences of the event, and whether one's personal values, norms, or standards correspond with the situation. Typically, appraisal theorists argue that discrete emotions result by combining these dimensions in order to form a profile of a particular feeling (Scherer, 1999).

Thus, despite their common negative valence, emotions like anger, sadness, fear, disgust, etc. arise due to different assessments of the situation. By investigating these feeling states along key differences in their appraisals, it becomes possible to predict when people will experience a specific emotion. Further, the experience of felt emotions carries over to influence subsequent appraisals, feelings, and actions. As such, it is important to differentiate between appraisals in order to uncover the precise mechanism at work and to predict and guide downstream effects on attitudes and behavior.

Anger is a negative emotional reaction arising from appraisals that a goal has been obstructed or when a situation is perceived to be incongruent with a person's motives – particularly centered around concerns related to social order and affronts to the self – and when individuals feel that they have the power or the capability to deal with the transgression and take action to change what has happened (Ellsworth & Scherer, 2003; Frijda, Kuipers, & Ter Schure, 1989; Lerner & Tiedens, 2006; Ortony, Clore, & Collins, 1988; Scherer, 1999). In an intergroup context, anger can be elicited when in-group members perceive threats to economic resources, property, personal freedoms, or in-group coordination (Cottrell & Neuberg, 2005). Prior work supports the notion that rage, a more intense, violent, uncontrolled anger, is a common part of the fan experience, especially when spectators are highly identified with their team, when intense rivalries exist, or when such emotions are perceived to give one's team a competitive advantage (Jones, Grove, & Pickett, 2010).

In a sponsorship context, we argue that anger is the most likely emotion to arise in response to the perceived threat of a rival sponsorship. The type of harm enacted in a sponsorship context is one of offense or the imposition of an obstacle to the in-group's success. In other words, fans are likely to react by thinking, “How dare that sponsor think a rival team is better than mine,” or, “That brand is helping the other team win.” Further, the capacity for fans to cope with such a transgression is high; fans enjoy a great deal of power in their relationships with sponsors because sponsors have a vested interest in keeping consumers happy. Fans can react against sponsors that displease them by complaining (to the company and to other consumers), boycotting, or ignoring future persuasive attempts. Thus, both the target of concern and ability to cope suggest that threat from partnering with a rival team should lead to anger.

While we expected that threat after encountering sponsorship of a rival would predominantly give rise to anger, we note that individuals may also experience multiple emotions rather than a single emotion in isolation. In particular, perceptions of threat commonly lead to feelings of both anger and fear – in their findings, Scherer and Tannenbaum (1986) note that these emotions, “tend to occur more frequently in combination with one another than singly” (p. 304; see also Berkowitz & Harmon-Jones, 2004). To illustrate, consider an athlete who has just suffered a concussion due to an opponent's reckless behavior – for example, a hit from behind in ice hockey. Fans are likely to feel both angry that the opponent broke the rules and disregarded the norms of fair play, and also fearful for the athlete's personal safety and the future performance of the team. In the same vein, fans may also feel simultaneously angry and afraid: “That brand is helping the other team win,” could lead to fears that one's favored team will be less competitive in the future along with feelings of anger that the brand has chosen to align with the rival. Note that the character of the emotional response changes depending on the way in which these statements are considered – in contrast to anger, fear is caused by appraisals of situational control (rather than personal control), uncertainty (rather than certainty), and an inability to cope with or influence future events (rather

than an ability to do so; Ellsworth & Scherer, 2003; Lerner & Keltner, 2001; Smith & Ellsworth, 1985). Thus, thinking about the unfairness of a rival receiving support is most likely to stoke feelings of anger, while considering the future advantages that support might give the rival in the future may also give rise to fear.

Consistent with the previous discussion on identification and team sponsorship, we suggest that team sponsorship moderates how highly identified fans perceive threat from the sponsorship of a rival and subsequently how threat contributes to feelings of anger and fear in tandem. Thus, we propose the following moderated mediation hypothesis:

H2. The mediating role of threat is conditional on team sponsorship, such that threat mediates the positive effect of identification on (a) anger and (b) fear in only the context of a rival team sponsorship (vs. a favored team sponsorship).

2.3. Attitudinal and behavioral consequences of threat and anger (but not fear)

We now turn to the question of how anger and fear will affect fans' attitudes and purchase intentions towards the team-brand partnership in response to perceived threat. A large body of research on the Appraisal Tendency Framework (ATF) has shown that felt emotions also give rise to a predictable set of appraisals which guide subsequent judgments, attitudes, and decisions, including those made in a social context (Han, Lerner, & Keltner, 2007; Lerner & Keltner, 2001; Lerner & Tiedens, 2006). In other words, emotions arise from cognitive underpinnings, and those felt emotions subsequently shape people's experiences.

Anger leads people to make more biased and heuristic judgments, to be punitive, to assign blame, to become less trusting, to take risks, and to lash out at others in response to perceived harm (Baumeister, Smart, & Boden, 1996; DeSteno, Dasgupta, Bartlett, & Caidric, 2004; Lerner & Keltner, 2001; Lerner & Tiedens, 2006). Anger also pushes people forward, prompting action against threatening stimuli (Frijda et al., 1989; Kish-Gephart, Detert, Treviño, & Edmondson, 2009; Yan & Dillard, 2010). Not only does anger lead to action tendencies against an out-group but also to action tendencies against other entities associated with an out-group (Van Zomeren, Spears, Fischer, & Leach, 2004). Sometimes sports fans channel their intense anger (i.e., rage) into extreme behavioral responses that are harmful and antisocial, resulting in violence or the disruption of the event (e.g. fighting, throwing objects onto the field of play, etc.) (Jones et al., 2010). However, sometimes anger can be functional, such as creating an intimidating atmosphere for a visiting team or deepening a fan's connection to the favored team. With any emotion, a fan's behavioral response is a matter of degree. In a sponsorship context, the anger that fans feel in response to the sponsorship of a rival is not likely to induce violent tendencies (as with rage) but is likely to motivate them to punish the sponsor with their thoughts and with their wallets, via negative attitudes towards the sponsor and reduced purchase intentions for the sponsor's offering.

In contrast, behavioral responses from fear are characterized by caution and tentativeness. People who are afraid tend to feel more uncertain about the future and compensate by making more risk-avoidant choices. Fear also causes people to be more pessimistic and more likely to believe that events are under situational control, in that individual actions will have little effect. Finally, fearful individuals process information more deeply, relying less heavily on snap judgments and mental shortcuts and more heavily on complex thought to improve their understanding of situations (Han et al., 2007; Lerner, Gonzalez, Small, & Fischhoff, 2003; Lerner & Keltner, 2001; Tiedens & Linton, 2001).

We expect that fan anger – rather than fear – will lead to attitudinal and behavioral change in response to a rival's sponsorship because of differences in how those two emotions influence future experiences.

Specifically, we expect that the heuristic, punitive nature of anger will translate to retributive attitudes and behavioral intentions in response to a rival sponsorship – angry fans are likely to make rash judgments that guide their future intentions. In contrast, the much more uncertain, cautious nature of fear should not cause fans to lash out at brands that cultivate partnerships with rival teams. Thus, we expect that anger but not fear will mediate the effect of threat onto subsequent attitudes towards the team-brand sponsor partnership. Further, it is expected that attitudes towards the team-brand partnership will mediate the relationship between anger and intentions to purchase the brand. Thus, we posit the final two hypotheses:

H3. The mediating role of anger is conditional on team sponsorship, such that anger mediates the negative effect of threat on attitudes in only the context of a rival team sponsorship (vs. a favored team sponsorship).

H4. The mediating role of attitude is conditional on team sponsorship, such that attitudes mediate the negative effect of anger on purchase intentions in only the context of a rival team sponsorship (vs. a favored team sponsorship).

2.4. Conceptual model

We propose a novel mechanism through which a rival sponsorship influences attitudes and purchase intentions for a sponsoring brand. The proposed model centers around perceptions of threat and resultant emotions to predict attitudes and purchase intentions (see Fig. 1). We propose that when highly identified fans encounter a sponsorship highlighting a partnership with a rival team, such a sponsorship will represent a threat to their extended self and the perceived resources of their team. This threat will lead to a mixture of anger and fear. Feelings of anger should drive an increase in negative attitudes and a reduction in purchase intentions, while the feelings of fear will not produce negative attitudes and intentions. Our model builds upon complementary findings in psychology (Cottrell & Neuberg, 2005) and health communications (Becheur & Valette-Florence, 2014) showing links between threat perceptions, negative emotions, and actions.

2.5. Overview of studies

We investigated these hypotheses using a collegiate sports context.

Two studies were conducted with students affiliated with an NCAA Division-I institution known for its longstanding rivalry with another in-state institution. All participants were recruited from the same institution. Study 1 examines how team sponsorship moderates the direct effect of identification on threat and the mediating role of threat. Study 2 provides a second test of the first and second hypotheses but also considers how team sponsorship moderates the mediating roles of anger and attitudes.

3. Study 1

3.1. Participants and procedures

In an online lab setting, 160 student participants from a large university in the northwestern United States were first instructed that they would be viewing and evaluating prototype advertising. After submitting an online consent to participate form and reading instructions about data collection procedures, participants were randomly assigned to view one of two ads containing the team sponsorship manipulation (favored team or rival team). Team sponsorship was manipulated as a between-subjects factor using team logos. Participants assigned to the favored team condition encountered a prototype ad indicating support for a team from the same university from which the students were recruited. Those assigned to the rival team condition encountered a prototype ad indicating support for a team from the in-state rival university. Each ad featured the same generic color image and typography. Time frame (that the brand had sponsored the team in the past or intends to do so in the future) was also varied to investigate a different hypothesis not related to this research. Time frame was not found to have an effect on any of the variables considered in Study 1 (all p s > 0.22). We collapsed across this factor for the following analyses.

3.2. Measures

After viewing the prototype ad, participants responded to a series of online measures. Threat towards the partnership was assessed with the following five items adapted from Dalton and Huang (2014): threatened, attacked, challenged, unhappy, uncomfortable ($M = 1.63$, $\alpha = 0.80$) in response to the prompt: “Please indicate the extent to which you felt each of the following in response to the partnership.” Each item was measured on a 7-point scale (1 = not at all, 7 = a great deal).

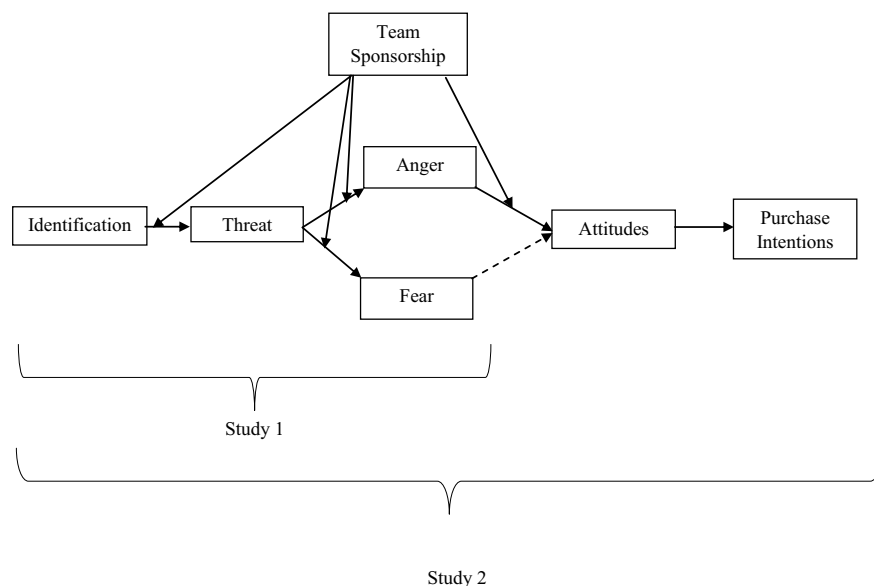


Fig. 1. Hypothesized relationships.

Table 1
Study 1 means and standard deviation.

	Favored team <i>n</i> = 78	Rival team <i>n</i> = 82	Overall <i>n</i> = 160
Threat	1.45 (0.64)	1.81 (1.07)	1.63 (0.91)
Anger	1.65 (0.76)	2.20 (1.34)	1.93 (1.12)
Fear	1.33 (0.68)	1.44 (0.80)	1.38 (0.75)
Identification	3.60 (0.79)	3.59 (0.88)	3.59 (0.83)

Note: Identification is based on identification with the favored team regardless of team sponsorship.

Table 2
Study 1 correlations among constructs.

	Threat	Anger	Fear	Identification
Threat	0.80			
Anger	0.79**	0.83		
Fear	0.56**	0.48**	0.75	
Identification	0.08	0.06	−0.05	0.86

Notes: Cronbach's alpha reliability along the diagonal, ***p* < .01, **p* < .05.

For anger and fear, participants were asked “To what extent do you feel each of the following emotions in response to the partnership.” Anger was assessed with the following four items: angry, irritated, frustrated, and displeased (*M* = 1.93, α = 0.83) and fear was assessed with the following three items: worried, nervous, fearful (*M* = 1.38, α = 0.75). Both anger and fear were measured on 7-point scales (1 = do not feel at all, 7 = feel a great deal).

All participants reported their identification with the favored team (i.e., home team) with six statements adapted from Mael and Ashforth (1992) (*M* = 3.59, α = 0.86) that were measured on a 5-point scale (1 = strongly disagree, 5 = strongly agree). Participant identification with the home team did not differ between participants exposed to the favored team condition and participants exposed to the rival team condition ($M_{\text{favored condition}} = 3.60$, $M_{\text{rival condition}} = 3.59$; *t* (158) = −0.10, *p* = .92). The nonsignificant difference indicates that the team manipulation did not influence participants' identification with their home team. Means and standard deviations for these measures can be found in Table 1 and correlations among constructs and Cronbach's alpha reliabilities can be found in Table 2.

3.3. Results

3.3.1. Analysis procedures

In order to test the first hypothesis, we followed the procedures recommended by Aiken and West (1991) for examining interactions between categorical and continuous variables. Team sponsorship dummy codes (0 = favored team, 1 = rival team) were used to compare the favored team sponsorship with the rival team sponsorship on perceptions of threat. Identification was mean-centered and the Team Sponsorship $\times$ Identification interaction was calculated with the dummy-coded team sponsorship and the mean-centered identification variables. Follow-up investigation included a simple slope analysis.

Moderated mediation and the total, direct, and indirect effects were assessed with multiple group structural equation modeling (Amos 23.0) with 2000 bootstrap samples. To specifically examine the differences between groups, critical ratios for differences between parameters and chi-square difference tests were used (see Table 3). Chi-square difference tests are an indicator of measurement invariance across groups (i.e., rival vs. favored team sponsorship). They are conducted by constraining the relevant parameters to be equal between groups.

3.3.2. Hypothesis 1. Team sponsorship $\times$ identification

As expected, the interaction of identification and team sponsorship was significant (β = 0.23, *t*(156) = 1.95, *p* < .05). To interpret the

Table 3
Study 1 Test of Moderated Mediation.

Path	Favored Team	Rival Team	
	Coefficient (95% CI)	Coefficient (95% CI)	
<i>Total Effects</i>			
Identification $\rightarrow$ Anger	-.17 (-.34, .01)	.13 (-.05, .30)	
Identification $\rightarrow$ Fear	-.02 (-.24, .17)	.05 (-.19, .27)	
<i>Direct Effects</i>			
Identification $\rightarrow$ Threat (H1)	-.07 (-.24, .05)	.22* (.04, .37)	CR Diff 1.96*
Identification $\rightarrow$ Anger	-.12 (-.27, .06)	-.04 (-.15, .08)	0.40
Identification $\rightarrow$ Fear	.01 (-.21, .19)	-.12 (-.26, .03)	-1.08
Threat $\rightarrow$ Anger	.70** (.54, .80)	.77** (.67, .85)	1.67†
Threat $\rightarrow$ Fear	.35* (.07, .59)	.81** (.69, .88)	2.51*
<i>Indirect Effects</i>			
Identification $\rightarrow$ Threat $\rightarrow$ Anger (H2a)	-.05 (-.16, .03)	.17* (.02, .29)	χ^2 Diff 6.57*
Identification $\rightarrow$ Threat $\rightarrow$ Fear (H2b)	-.03 (-.08, .02)	.18* (.03, .31)	9.95*

** *p* < .01

* *p* < .05

† *p* < .10

significant interaction, we examined the simple slopes within each team condition. Results were consistent with the first hypothesis. Highly identified fans exposed to the rival team sponsorship experienced significantly higher levels of threat compared to less identified fans exposed to the rival sponsorship (b = 0.23, *t*(156) = 2.07, *p* < .05). The level of threat did not differ between highly identified and less identified fans in the favored team sponsorship condition (b = −0.10, *t* (156) = −0.76, *p* > .45). The main effect of team sponsorship was significant (β = 0.20, *t*(156) = 2.54, *p* < .05). Those exposed to the rival team condition indicated greater threat than those exposed to the favored team condition. The main effect of identification on threat was not significant (*p* > .40).

The results from the Amos multiple group analysis also supported H1. Identification had a positive direct effect on threat in the rival team condition ($ML_{\text{est}} = 0.22$, CI = 0.04, 0.37), suggesting those who were increasingly identified experienced higher levels of threat. In contrast, the relationship between identification and threat was not significant in the favored team condition ($ML_{\text{est}} = -0.07$, CI = −0.24, 0.05). The critical ratio for differences between parameters indicated that the magnitude of the association between identification and threat was significantly different between the rival and favored team sponsorship ($CR_{\text{diff}} = 1.96$, *p* < .05). These findings support the first hypothesis.

3.3.3. Hypothesis 2. Moderated mediation: Mediating role of threat

Support was found for moderated mediation in the second hypothesis. For the rival team sponsorship, the conditional indirect effect of identification through threat was positive and significant for both anger ($ML_{\text{est}} = 0.17$, CI = 0.02, 0.29) and for fear ($ML_{\text{est}} = 0.18$, CI = 0.03, 0.31). In the favored team condition, the conditional indirect effect was not significant for either anger ($ML_{\text{est}} = -0.05$, CI = −0.16, 0.03) or fear ($ML_{\text{est}} = -0.03$, CI = −0.08, 0.02). A chi-square difference test indicated that the indirect path of the rival team sponsorship was significantly greater than the indirect path of the favored team sponsorship for both anger ($\chi^2_{\text{diff}} = 6.57$, *p* < .05) and for fear ($\chi^2_{\text{diff}} = 9.95$, *p* < .05). Thus, the second hypothesis was supported. Threat was found to mediate the effect of identification on the emotions

of anger and fear but only for a rival team sponsorship.

3.4. Discussion

The results of Study 1 provide an initial answer to our question of how fans respond to the sponsorship of a rival team. The results demonstrate that strongly identified fans feel threatened by the sponsorship of a rival. This same level of threat is not experienced by less identified fans or in reaction to the sponsorship of a favored team. In response to this perceived threat, strongly identified fans reacted with anger and fear. Thus, perceived threat was found to mediate identification on anger and fear in the rival team sponsorship condition but not the favored team sponsorship condition.

A limitation of Study 1 is that it did not include a brand sponsor. This was done to ensure that existing brand attitudes did not confound the manipulation of team sponsorship. However, in the marketplace, specific brands are identified as sponsors. Further, without an identified sponsor, it is not possible to ask participants about their attitudes or purchase intentions towards a brand. Therefore, Study 2 considers a sponsorship of a rival team using a fictitious brand.

The results of Study 1 suggest that sponsorship of a rival team evokes negative emotions, however that study did not include a test of how these emotions might impact the relative success of a sponsorship. Therefore, Study 2 also considers the attitudinal and behavioral consequences that result from the threat and negative emotional responses (i.e., anger and fear) observed in Study 1. We expected that anger should lead to more negative attitudes and reduced purchase intentions, but such outcomes should not result from feelings of fear.

4. Study 2

4.1. Participants and procedures

In an online lab setting, 186 student participants from a large university in the northwestern United States received instructions similar to those used in Study 1. After reading a consent to participate, study participants were randomly assigned to view one of two ads containing the team sponsorship manipulation. Team sponsorship was manipulated as a between-subjects factor (team: favored vs. rival) with team logos. Each ad featured the same generic color image and typography promoting a fictitious sponsor, a granola bar brand (Eden). Time frame was also varied and was not found to have an influence on the variables included in this analysis (all p s > 0.21). We collapsed across this factor for the following analyses.

4.2. Measures

Following the prototype advertising image, participants were presented with an online survey that included manipulation checks, an attention check, and study measures. Manipulation checks were included for the team sponsorship manipulation and for the brand featured in the ad. All participants indicated the correct team featured in the ad. However, five participants indicated the incorrect brand and were removed from analysis. An attention check question was also included. Eleven participants failed the attention check and were not included. Thus, 170 participants were included in subsequent analyses.

Identification, threat, anger, fear, attitude towards the sponsorship, and purchase intentions were assessed as measured variables. Threat, anger, and fear were assessed with the same prompts and items used in Study 1 ($M_{\text{threat}} = 1.82$, $M_{\text{anger}} = 1.90$, $M_{\text{fear}} = 1.33$). Identification with the favored team was assessed on a 7-point scale (1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree) with the same items as in Study 1 ($M_{\text{identification}} = 5.06$). Attitude towards the team-brand partnership was assessed with three 7-point semantic differential scales (very bad/very good, very unfavorable/very favorable, very negative/very positive; $M = 4.49$, $\alpha = 0.97$). Purchase intentions towards the sponsoring

Table 4

Study 2 means and standard deviations.

	Favored team <i>n</i> = 93	Rival team <i>n</i> = 77	Overall <i>n</i> = 170
Threat	1.34 (0.69)	2.40 (1.48)	1.82 (1.24)
Anger	1.49 (0.72)	2.40 (1.51)	1.90 (1.23)
Fear	1.23 (0.63)	1.46 (0.91)	1.33 (0.77)
Attitudes	5.37 (1.38)	3.42 (1.51)	4.49 (1.73)
Purchase intentions	3.36 (1.25)	2.98 (1.29)	3.19 (1.28)
Identification	5.06 (1.48)	5.06 (1.55)	5.06 (1.51)

Note: Identification is based on identification with the favored team regardless of team sponsorship.

granola bar brand were assessed with seven 7-point scales (unlikely/likely, absolutely certain/no chance (reverse-coded), never/definitely, certainly not/certainly yes, definitely do not intend to buy/definitely intend to buy, very low purchase interest/very high purchase interest, I would definitely not buy it/I would definitely buy it; $M = 3.19$, $\alpha = 0.95$). Means and standard deviations can be found in Table 4 and correlations among constructs and Cronbach's alpha reliabilities can be found in Table 5.

4.3. Results

4.3.1. Analysis procedures

The same analysis procedures and independent variable coding used in Study 1 were used to test the hypotheses in Study 2. That is, the team sponsorship dummy codes were used to examine the effect of team sponsorship on perceptions of threat in H1. We also followed the same multiple group analysis and bootstrapping procedures using Amos 23.0 in analyzing and reporting the results of moderated mediation. Table 6 provides standardized coefficients and 95% confidence intervals for total, direct, and indirect paths, as well as the critical ratios for differences between parameters and chi-square difference tests.

4.3.2. Hypothesis 1. Team sponsorship $\times$ identification

Consistent with the results of Study 1, the interaction of team sponsorship and identification on threat was significant ($\beta = 0.33$, $t(166) = 3.62$, $p < .01$). A simple slope analysis indicated that respondents who were highly identified and exposed to a sponsorship of a rival team experienced significantly higher levels of threat compared to those who were less identified and exposed to a rival team sponsorship ($b = 0.36$, $t(166) = 4.99$, $p < .01$). The level of threat did not differ between highly identified and less identified fans in the favored team sponsorship condition ($b = -0.03$, $t(166) = -0.39$, $p > .65$). Also consistent with the results of Study 1, the main effect of team sponsorship was significant ($\beta = 0.43$, $t(169) = 6.48$, $p < .01$), indicating that participants exposed to the rival sponsorship condition experienced higher levels of threat compared to those exposed to the favored sponsorship condition. The main effect of identification was not significant ($\beta = -0.04$, $t(166) = -0.38$, $p > .70$).

The multiple group analysis also supported the first hypothesis. That is, the effect of identification on threat was positive and significant for the rival team sponsorship ($ML_{\text{est}} = 0.38$, $CI = 0.25, 0.50$) but was not significant for the favored team sponsorship ($ML_{\text{est}} = -0.06$, $CI = -0.27, 0.11$). Thus, team sponsorship moderated the effect of identification on threat in the rival team sponsorship condition ($CR_{\text{diff}} = 3.50$, $p < .01$). Our findings support the first hypothesis.

4.3.3. Hypothesis 2. Moderated mediation: Threat as a mediator

The second hypothesis predicted that team sponsorship would moderate the mediating role of threat between identification and anger (H2a) and fear (H2b). In support of H2a, threat was found to mediate the effect of identification on anger for the rival team sponsorship ($ML_{\text{est}} = 0.24$, $CI = 0.15, 0.35$) but not for the favored team

Table 5
Study 2 correlations among constructs.

	Threat	Anger	Fear	Attitudes	Purchase intentions	Identification
Threat	0.91					
Anger	0.69**	0.89				
Fear	0.45**	0.53**	0.90			
Attitudes	−0.61**	−0.54**	−0.22**	0.97		
Purchase Int.	−0.16*	−0.24**	−0.06	0.39**	0.95	
Identification	0.19*	0.22**	0.12	−0.01	0.04	0.89

Notes: Cronbach's alpha reliability along the diagonal, ** $p < .01$, * $p < .05$.

Table 6
Study 2 Test of Moderated Mediation.

Path	Favored Team	Rival Team	
	Coefficient (95% CI)	Coefficient (95% CI)	
<i>Total Effects</i>			
Identification → Anger	-.07 (-.25, .07)	.43** (.31, .56)	
Identification → Fear	.04 (-.14, .14)	.19* (.03, .34)	
Identification → Attitudes	.34** (.16, .49)	-.39** (-.54, -.21)	
Identification → Purchase Intentions	.14 (-.08, .32)	-.08 (-.26, .10)	
Threat → Attitudes	-.38** (-.53, -.22)	-.50** (-.61, -.36)	
Threat → Purchase Intentions	.05 (-.10, .18)	-.19 (-.37, .02)	
Anger → Purchase Intentions	-.22* (-.39, -.04)	-.26* (-.59, -.19)	
Fear → Purchase Intentions	.14* (.03, .31)	.04 (-.24, .30)	
<i>Direct Effects</i>			CR Diff
Identification → Threat (H1)	-.06 (-.27, .11)	.38** (.25, .50)	3.50**
Identification → Anger	-.05 (-.22, .10)	.19** (.08, .33)	2.22*
Identification → Fear	.05 (-.13, .17)	-.01 (-.15, .16)	-.032
Identification → Attitudes	.32** (.15, .47)	-.12 (-.28, .05)	-3.32**
Identification → Purchase Intentions	-.002 (-.18, .19)	.10 (-.10, .26)	0.64
Threat → Anger	.35* (.14, .53)	.64** (.48, .77)	2.13*
Threat → Fear	.25* (.04, .44)	.52** (.34, .68)	0.87
Threat → Attitudes	-.37** (-.51, -.16)	-.36** (-.54, -.16)	1.51
Threat → Purchase Intentions	.24* (.06, .41)	.14 (-.11, .37)	-1.25
Anger → Attitudes	-.01 (-.16, .17)	-.41** (-.60, -.19)	-1.84†
Anger → Purchase Intentions	-.22* (-.40, -.03)	-.05 (-.42, .32)	1.51
Fear → Attitudes	-.04 (-.22, .16)	.24* (.07, .44)	1.87†
Fear → Purchase Intentions	.16* (.03, .31)	-.08 (-.39, .18)	-1.64
Attitudes → Purchase Intentions	.39** (.19, .58)	.50** (.29, .70)	0.37
<i>Indirect Effects - Anger</i>			χ^2 Diff
Identification → Threat → Anger (H2a)	-.022 (-.11, .04)	.24** (.15, .35)	16.05**
Threat → Anger → Attitudes (H3)	-.003 (-.12, .15)	-.27** (-.46, -.14)	7.34*
Anger → Attitudes → Purchase Intentions (H4)	-.002 (-.07, .07)	-.21** (-.38, -.10)	3.01
<i>Indirect Effects - Fear</i>			
Identification → Threat → Fear (H2b)	-.015 (-.08, .02)	.20** (.12, .33)	12.33**
Threat → Fear → Attitudes	-.020 (-.15, .07)	-.03 (-.19, .14)	3.72
Fear → Attitudes → Purchase Intentions	-.016 (-.09, .06)	.12* (.04, .24)	3.11

** $p < .01$

* $p < .05$

† $p < .10$

sponsorship ($ML_{est} = -0.02$, $CI = -0.11, 0.04$). A significant chi-square difference test ($\chi^2_{diff} = 16.05$, $p < .01$) indicates that the indirect effect of identification on anger through threat was significantly greater in the rival team sponsorship condition compared to the favored team sponsorship condition. Similar results were found for H2b. Threat mediated the effect of identification on fear but only in the rival team sponsorship condition ($ML_{est} = 0.20$, $CI = 0.12, 0.33$) and not in the favored team sponsorship condition ($ML_{est} = -0.02$, $CI = -0.08, 0.02$). The difference between the rival team and favored team indirect paths was significant ($\chi^2_{diff} = 12.33$, $p < .01$). We thus find additional support for both H2a and H2b, consistent with Study 1.

4.3.4. Hypothesis 3. Moderated mediation: Anger as a mediator

The third hypothesis posits that anger will mediate the effect of threat on attitudes towards the partnership in the rival team sponsorship condition but not in the favored team sponsorship condition. As

expected, the conditional indirect effect of threat on attitudes through anger was negative and significant for a rival team sponsorship ($ML_{est} = -0.27$, $CI = -0.46, -0.14$), whereas it was not significant for a favored team sponsorship ($ML_{est} = -0.003$, $CI = -0.12, 0.15$). A chi-square difference test indicates that the difference between the rival team sponsorship and favored team sponsorship was significant with anger as the mediator ($\chi^2_{diff} = 7.34$, $p < .05$). A significant conditional indirect effect was not found with fear as a mediator for either a rival team sponsorship ($ML_{est} = -0.03$, $CI = -0.19, 0.14$) or a favored team sponsorship ($ML_{est} = -0.02$, $CI = -0.15, 0.07$). These results support H3.

4.3.5. Hypothesis 4. Moderated mediation: Attitudes as a mediator

The final hypothesis proposed that attitudes mediate the effect of anger on purchase intentions for a rival sponsorship. As expected, the indirect negative influence of anger on purchase intentions through

attitudes was significant in the rival team condition ($ML_{est} = -0.21$, $CI = -0.38, -0.10$) but was not significant in the favored team condition ($ML_{est} = -0.002$, $CI = -0.07, 0.07$). Although the indirect effect was significant in the rival team sponsorship condition and the effect was not significant in the favored team condition, a chi-square difference test indicated that this difference was not significant ($\chi^2_{diff} = 3.01$, $p > .20$). Thus, our results only partially support H4.

4.4. Discussion

The results of Study 2 support and extend those of Study 1. As in Study 1, more strongly identified participants were the most likely to perceive a threat in response to the sponsorship of a rival team. Again, increased threat yielded both anger and fear in response to a rival sponsorship. Study 2 also measured attitudes towards the sponsorship and purchase intentions for the sponsor's product. Consistent with our hypotheses and prior literature, stronger feelings of anger led to more negative attitudes about the team-sponsor partnership and decreased purchase intentions for the brand. While the indirect effect on purchase intentions was significant and in the hypothesized direction for the rival team sponsorship condition and insignificant in the favored team condition, the non-significant chi-square difference test on this factor may be attributed to a floor effect; overall, purchase intentions for the product were relatively low, reducing the likelihood that they would be further diminished by anger. Substituting a product category with higher involvement and greater purchase intentions may make observing this difference more likely. Overall, our findings are congruent with our proposition that fans cope with threat and anger towards a rival's sponsor by avoiding or discriminating against the brand's products.

5. General discussion

Previous sponsorship research has established that sports fans develop negative attitudes in response to sponsors of their rivals (Bergkvist, 2012; Bee & Dalakas, 2015; Dalakas & Levin, 2005; Grohs et al., 2015). However, the cognitive and emotional processes underlying such responses have not yet been considered. The two studies presented here demonstrate that highly identified sports fans feel threatened by a brand's partnership with a rival, eliciting feelings of anger that translate to negative attitudes and purchase intentions towards the transgressor - the brand sponsor.

Conceptually, these findings offer a better understanding of the "us versus them" dichotomy through which sports fans view their own team and rivals. Sponsorships represent strategic decisions for companies; therefore, to a die-hard sports fan, a brand partnering with a rival represents a conscious decision to willingly side with "them" rather than with "us." To highly identified fans, this support implies that the sponsor of a rival believes that "they" are better than "us." Given the intense emotional nature of fandom, it is not surprising that such behavior angers fans. These studies offer a theoretical contribution by demonstrating the mechanism through which negative affect transfer occurs.

5.1. Implications - identification

Consistent with previous research (e.g., Bee & Dalakas, 2015; Grohs et al., 2015), our results show that not all fans are equally affected by the sponsorship of a rival. Less identified fans view their affiliation with a sports team as representing a smaller component of their self-concept relative to more highly identified fans. For this reason, these fans perceived less threat and subsequent anger and fear in response to the sponsorship of a rival team. Thus, a contribution of this research is in developing a better theoretical understanding of the relationship between identification and fans' cognitive, emotional and behavioral responses to sponsorship.

5.2. Implications - appraisal theory

Lazarus (2000) argues that appraisal theory offers great benefit to understanding and improving athletic performance in competitive sports. He writes, "In much research, it is common to group negatively toned emotions together and to regard this group as the polar opposite of positively toned emotions...To emphasize these two groupings is, I believe, a strategic mistake because it overlooks the extent to which each individual emotion is distinctive with respect to its antecedents, subjective experience, and outcome" (p. 232). Likewise, we argue that sponsorships provide another context to effectively employ appraisal theory; by adding nuance to the current attitudinal and valence-based perspective of "positive vs. negative" responses to sponsorships, our findings can help teams and brands to understand and predict the performance of their sponsorship investments.

Using an appraisal theory perspective, our research identified anger as a specific emotion experienced in response to a perceived threat. The partnership of the rival team with the sponsoring brand served as a perceived threat to the identity of devoted and passionate fans. Perceived threat acted as a mediator of the team sponsorship $\times$ identification interaction on anger. And, consistent with an appraisal theory perspective, fans channeled their anger in a punitive fashion by cultivating negative attitudes and reduced purchase intentions for the sponsor's offering. Conversely, fear (another negatively-valenced emotion) did not have these same motivational consequences. Fear did not stoke the same retributive responses that we observed via anger. The finding that anger, rather than fear, underlies fan responses to a rival sponsorship suggests that these fans are more reliant on biased, heuristic decision making and are likely to take action to correct the perceived transgression. Thus, our studies highlight the importance in anticipating specific emotional responses rather than considering only valence.

6. Practical implications, limitations, and future research

Based on our findings a promising, practical extension might explore how the emotional framing of a sponsorship affects perceptions of threat and any subsequent appraisals and emotional and behavioral consequences. Such differences in emotional framing may be more or less subtle. For example, portraying the partnership in a way that evokes fear rather than anger may be a way to avoid backlash. A sponsor may use a tagline like, "In this game, you never know what will happen..." thereby evoking themes of uncertainty and situational control in order to encourage a fear response and neutralize negative reactions from rival fans. Other negative emotions like sadness, disappointment, or disgust may also be relevant. For instance, in the example discussed earlier, had Alaska Airlines sponsored the Seattle Sounders it is unlikely that Portland Timbers fans would have reacted as strongly as Sounders fans. Although the airline operates in both cities, its corporate headquarters is located in Seattle. In this way, the brand's sponsorship of a rival may have been understood as inevitable, less blameworthy and less of a transgression. Although such a sponsorship may still be viewed unfavorably by rival fans, the difference in appraisals might result in disappointment or sadness rather than anger, causing different motivational and behavioral consequences, akin to the differences we observed between anger and fear.

Brands may also address this issue by sponsoring multiple teams, especially when they are in close geographic proximity and when the brand can position itself as sponsoring the rivalry itself, not one team or the other. This is a fairly common approach by many sponsors who attempt to not take sides and risk angering fans from any one side. For example, Dunkin' Donuts sponsors both Major League Baseball teams in Chicago, the Cubs and the White Sox. Using these sponsorships, Dunkin' Donuts touts the brand as the official sponsor of Chicago baseball in general, rather than focusing on either specific team. Similarly, Italian supermarket Decò is a sponsor of both AS Roma and Lazio, which are

bitter cross-town rivals in the Italian Serie A League. By doing so, brands can position their sponsorship as more compatible with norms or standards that fans hold – they treasure the rivalry and part of what makes the rivalry great is that both teams are strong. Although this appraisal reduces the likelihood of anger, future research should explore the cognitive, emotional, and behavioral consequences of such a joint partnership.

New work in appraisal theory may also shed additional light for future research on the complex emotional processes that fans undergo when encountering a piece of sponsorship communication. So et al. (2015) argue that marketers can profitably extend research on appraisals by examining how dimensions such as valence interact with each other or by identifying novel appraisal dimensions. One such novel appraisal dimension that they highlight is other deservingness, which is created by inducing different types of envy. Envy is a negatively-valenced emotion that arises when people make upward comparisons to the good fortune of others. In other words, people feel envious when someone else has something that they want (Van de Ven, Zeelenberg, & Pieters, 2009). Although not considered in our studies, such a feeling may arise when a fan encounters the sponsorship of a rival. Envy is resolved by narrowing the gap between oneself and another person, which could happen by denigrating the other's position, or improving one's own. Van de Ven et al. (2009) differentiate between two types of envy that approximately correspond to these two realities – malicious and benign envy. Malicious envy is negative and frames others as undeserving of their superior position, and benign envy, while still painful, spurs admiration of the other and a somewhat positive motivation to improve oneself. It is possible that sponsorship messaging that promotes benign envy may help consumers to turn their negative feelings into a reinforcement of the positive aspects of the rivalry, rather than a punishment of the sponsoring property. For example, advertising the financial gains Alaska Airlines receives through their Portland Timbers sponsorship might evoke benign envy because companies are expected to take action to improve profits. In contrast, a promotion that connected goals scored by the Timbers to discounts offered by Alaska Airlines might evoke more malicious envy because the success of the promotion tied to a gain that is perceived as undeserved by rival fans.

Finally, while the current research demonstrated a comprehensive process implicating threat, anger/fear, attitudes, and intentions – consumers' reactions to rivalries are complex and are likely multifaceted. Our research examined purchase intentions as a key outcome, future work should also consider other consumer behaviors in reaction to rival sponsorships such as complaining, in-game behavior, or fan reactions on social media. More detail can also be shed on the mechanisms underlying affect transfer. For example, our studies consider brand-property sponsorships in relation to fan identification. However, future research might offer additional nuance by considering the relationships between fans, events involving team members, events involving the brand and how those contribute to perceptions of property-brand sponsorships.

It is also important to recognize the limitations associated with an experimental approach and our student sample. An experimental approach enhanced internal validity and allowed for a test of specific relationships, however, consistent with previous sponsorship research (e.g., Lacey, Close, & Finney, 2010; Lacey, Sneath, Finney, & Close, 2007), field studies and/or more naturalistic settings would provide greater ecological validity and would be more likely to reflect the emotionally intense environment of an experiential sporting event. Furthermore, experiments using existing (rather than fictitious) brands should also be considered to further validate our findings. We also used a student sample, which capitalized on student identification and involvement with their university's sports teams, however future research should also be conducted with other sports fans.

In closing, our research reveals important insights into how consumers react to brand-team partnerships that can help researchers and

managers design materials that deliver the desired changes to attitudes and behaviors. A better understanding of such sponsorships will help brands avoid unintended consequences like the hate mail received when a brand like Alaska Airlines picks the “wrong” side of a heated rivalry.

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